

Ellan Vannin Wealth Management

Sovereign Urban Infrastructure Investment Memorandum

The Birmingham Blue Corridor Renaissance Programme

Canal Modernisation, Water Transport & Canalside Regeneration Strategy

Turning Birmingham's Industrial Waterways into a 21st Century Economic Asset

Executive Summary

Ellan Vannin Wealth Management (EVWM) proposes the creation of the:

Birmingham Blue Corridor Investment Fund

A long-term sovereign-style infrastructure investment programme to transform Birmingham's historic canal network into:

- a leisure boating destination
- a slow-speed urban transport network
- a sustainable freight corridor
- a major canalside property development opportunity
- a blue-green regeneration spine

Birmingham possesses one of the largest urban canal networks in Europe. The city has approximately 35 miles of canals within Birmingham itself, while the wider Birmingham Canal Navigations (BCN) network exceeds 100 miles. Historically these waterways moved coal, iron and manufactured goods that powered Birmingham's industrial rise.

The investment thesis:

The canals that built industrial Birmingham can become the infrastructure that regenerates post-industrial Birmingham.

Strategic Vision

From Industrial Canal City to Blue Urban Economy

Birmingham has historically treated canals as heritage assets.

EVWM proposes treating them as:

Economic Infrastructure

Comparable to:

- railways
- roads
- airports
- digital networks

The objective is to create:

The Birmingham Blue Corridor

A connected network of:

- housing
 - offices
 - restaurants
 - tourism
 - transport
 - logistics
 - public spaces
-

Investment Opportunity

The city contains extensive brownfield and former industrial land along canals.

These locations have several advantages:

- existing transport corridors
- proximity to city centre
- historic character
- waterside amenity
- regeneration potential

Existing Birmingham planning frameworks have already identified the canal corridor as a major regeneration opportunity, particularly around areas such as the city centre canal corridor and Digbeth.

Fund Structure

Birmingham Blue Corridor Fund

Total Investment:

£3 billion

Over:

25 years

Capital Sources:

Investor	Contribution
EVWM	£750m
Pension funds	£1.25bn
Property investors	£500m
Government/local partnership	£500m

Pillar One

Canal Infrastructure Upgrade Programme

Investment:

£750 million

Objective

Upgrade canals from historic waterways into modern urban assets.

Engineering Works

1. Lock Modernisation

Upgrade:

- gates
- water control

- navigation systems

Benefits:

- faster journeys
 - improved reliability
 - increased tourism
-

2. Digital Canal Network

Install:

- smart monitoring
 - water management
 - navigation information
 - booking systems
-

3. Canal Edge Improvements

Create:

- promenades
 - cycle routes
 - lighting
 - public spaces
-

4. Environmental Improvements

Investment in:

- biodiversity
 - water quality
 - urban cooling
 - flood management
-

Pillar Two

Birmingham Water Transport Network

"The Slow Mobility Revolution"

Investment:

£500 million

The aim is not to replace rail.

Instead:

Create a slower, more human-scale transport system connecting neighbourhoods.

Proposed Routes

Route 1

City Centre Loop

Gas Street Basin

↓

Brindleyplace

↓

Jewellery Quarter

↓

Eastside

Route 2

Digbeth Creative Corridor

HS2 Curzon Street

↓

Digbeth

↓

Grand Union Canal

Route 3

University & Innovation Route

City Centre

↓

University of Birmingham

↓

Canal districts

Transport Vehicles

Introduce:

- electric canal boats
 - autonomous water taxis
 - solar-assisted passenger vessels
-

Capacity:

Small-scale:

25 passengers per vessel

Use cases:

- commuting
 - tourism
 - events
 - conferences
-

Journey Philosophy

Not:

"fast transport"

but:

"pleasant movement"

A Birmingham equivalent of:

- Amsterdam canal mobility
 - Venice water transport
 - Copenhagen harbour routes
-

Pillar Three

Sustainable Urban Freight Network

Investment:

£400 million

Historically Birmingham's canals moved millions of tonnes of goods. At its peak, canal traffic was central to the city's industrial economy.

EVWM proposes a modern revival.

Modern Freight Uses

Last-Mile Logistics

Electric canal barges carrying:

- parcels
 - construction materials
 - food deliveries
 - waste collection
-

Example

A warehouse near:

Digbeth

↓

Electric barge

↓

City-centre delivery hub

↓

Cargo bikes/electric vans

Benefits:

- fewer HGVs

- reduced congestion
 - lower emissions
-

Pillar Four

Birmingham Canal Property Renaissance

Investment:

£1.2 billion

The largest financial opportunity.

Development Model

EVWM acquires:

- derelict warehouses
- brownfield plots
- unused industrial sites

along waterways.

Redevelop into:

Residential

- apartments
 - townhouses
 - build-to-rent
-

Commercial

- offices
 - studios
 - workshops
-

Leisure

- restaurants
 - hotels
 - cafés
-

Target Development

10,000 New Homes

along canal corridors.

Average development value:

£250,000/unit

Gross property creation:

£2.5 billion

Key Development Zones

1. Digbeth Canal Quarter

Vision:

Birmingham's Shoreditch.

Uses:

- creative industries
 - technology
 - independent businesses
 - housing
-

2. Eastside Blue District

Connected to:

- HS2 Curzon Street

- universities
 - innovation economy
-

3. Gas Street Basin Expansion

Transform into:

Birmingham's waterfront district.

4. Aston Canal Innovation Corridor

Industrial regeneration.

Pillar Five

Birmingham Canal Tourism Economy

Investment:

£150 million

Create:

Birmingham Canal Experience

A new visitor economy.

Components:

- heritage boats
 - canal hotels
 - floating restaurants
 - festivals
 - museums
-

Target:

Increase canal tourism visitors:

+2 million annually

Economic effect:

Hospitality spending:

£100m+ annually

Financial Model

Investment

£3 billion

Asset Creation

Asset	Value
Property development	£2.5bn
Transport infrastructure	£750m
Commercial assets	£500m

Revenue Streams

Property

Rental income:

£100m/year

Retail & Hospitality

£50m/year

Transport operations

£20m/year

Freight services

£15m/year

Mature Annual Revenue

£185 million+

Employment Impact

Construction:

30,000 job-years

Permanent:

- hospitality
- transport
- property management
- logistics
- technology

Estimated:

15,000 jobs

GDP Impact

The West Midlands economy is already one of Britain's largest regional economies.

The regeneration effect comes from:

- land value uplift
 - productivity gains
 - tourism
 - reduced congestion
 - increased housing supply
-

Conservative Estimate

Annual economic uplift:

£750 million–£1 billion GVA

Growth Scenario

With HS2, airport expansion and wider Birmingham regeneration:

£1.5 billion annual GVA uplift

Relationship With HS2

The canal network becomes the missing urban layer around HS2.

HS2 creates:

fast regional connections.

The canals create:

slow local connections.

Together:

Birmingham gains both speed and quality of life.

Strategic Comparison

Infrastructure	Function
HS2	Fast national connectivity
Rail	Regional commuting
Canals	Local mobility + regeneration
Roads	Freight and logistics

Final Recommendation

Ellan Vannin Wealth Management recommends establishing:

The Birmingham Blue Corridor Fund

A sovereign-style investment vehicle to transform Birmingham's canals into a new economic ecosystem.

The programme would:

- regenerate brownfield land
- create thousands of homes
- restore historic infrastructure
- reduce congestion
- create tourism assets
- introduce sustainable freight
- improve quality of life

The central investment thesis:

Birmingham does not need to hide its industrial past. It needs to monetise it.

The canals that created Birmingham's industrial wealth can become the foundation of its next economic renaissance.